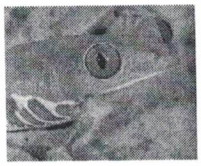
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Mrs. Needy



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By David Ralph

Teaser:

Mrs. Needy: Good morning class, my name is Mrs. Alneeda, but you can call me Mrs. Needy. For most of you today is the first day of pre-school, exciting! Before you all become big boys and girls and go to kindergarten we will learn about all sorts of fun things, like animals, colors, numbers, and the alphabet. Do any of you know what the alphabet is?

Johnny: Is that kind of like my teddy bear?

Mrs. Needy: No Johnny, but it does have a B in it, and do you know what starts with a B? Bear. O.K. lets all put on our listening ears and follow me to the circle area over in the corner. *(Acts like an airplane zooming to the corner)*

Sara: I have to go potty.

Mrs. Needy: Hurry up dear.

End Teaser:

Mrs. Needy: She was so beautiful, the perfect little girl. Everyday she wore wonderful dresses in different shades of pink; I would call her Ms. Pretty Cindy in pink; pink everyday; her favorite color. Her hair, her hair was golden and stretched like a sunset for miles; always combed straight and the smell of baby shampoo from her hair found a permanent home in my nose. As soon as she walked into my classroom she would bring a smile to my face. Everyday she would bounce through the door full of life and her energy would fight her skin to escape from the body into wide-open spaces. I loved how she would say "Hello Mrs. Needy. How are you?" Every morning, "How are you?" Towards the end of it all that's what kept me going to work, just to hear her ask me how I was. She was so perfect, angelic in all her innocence to the world around her. Is she all right now? Tell me! Is she all right? What do you mean you don't know?! Find her!

Johnny: Mrs. Needy what does beer taste like?

Mrs. Needy: Johnny, how do you know about beer?

Johnny: My daddy drinks it all the time after work, but mommy won't let me take a drink. You know everything, what does beer taste like?

Mrs. Needy: Well Johnny it's real yucky and it only tastes good to some grown ups, but kids should never drink it because it will make them sick for days. Do you promise me you'll never take a drink of your daddy's beer?

Johnny: Yes, Mrs. Needy, I promise.

Cindy: Hello Mrs. Needy. How are you?

Mrs. Needy: I'm doing excellent today Ms. Pretty Cindy in pink. See you in the afternoon Mrs. Shapen, Cindy and I are going to have some fun today. *(Waves goodbye to mother)* Did you get a new dress?

Cindy: Yes, mommy took me shopping last night for losing a tooth. Look. *(Shows missing tooth)*

Mrs. Needy: My Cindy you sure are getting to be a big girl and so pretty. Come here and give me a hug. *(Hugging gesture)*

(Still holding a hugging gesture but stops when she knows she is being watch) I told you I don't know anything; I just don't know. The night before? I was at home with my husband watching television, we watched NBC for most of the night and then switched over to CBS to watch Dave Letterman, I can't stand Jay Leno. After the opening monologue we went to bed. I don't think my relationship with my husband has anything to do with anything. Am I being accused of something here, because I didn't do anything, why would I do anything? I loved that girl like she was my own child. If you want to do something to help then why aren't you out there searching for her, she's probably scared to death and all you can do is stand there and ask me questions like what I was doing the night before she was taken and how my relationship is with my husband?!
(Sits, breaths deep, and thinks for a minute)
I'm sorry it's just well, that little girl meant so much to me. She really was special and I just want to see her safe. She needs to be in the arms of someone who loves her instead of out there. If you think these questions will help then I'll try to remain calm and answer them to the best of my knowledge and ability. The faster I answer the faster you can get out there and find her.

Mrs. Needy: All right who put their number two on the bathroom floor? Huh? I want to know right now or we won't go out to recess like the other preschool rooms. *(Stares at the kids)*

Johnny: Mrs. Needy?

Mrs. Needy: Yes Johnny?

Johnny: I think it was the poo fairy.
Mrs. Needy: I'm sorry Johnny, what did you say?

Johnny: I think it was the poo fairy who did it.

Mrs. Needy: The poo fairy huh? O.k. everyone can get in line at the red door behind Mrs. Christy for recess, except for you Johnny. I need to talk to you for a second. *(Give a beat or two for the students to leave)* Johnny you can tell me if you did it or not. You won't get in trouble.

Johnny: ... well…ummm…see the poo fairy told me that if I put my poo on the floor then she would turn the poo into lots and lots of money. I'm sorry Mrs. Needy. I won't listen to the poo fairy anymore.

Mrs. Needy: You better not listen to that poo fairy anymore or I'll have to have a serious talk with your mom and dad.

Johnny: You wouldn't be able to talk with my dad anymore. He left me and mom. I don't think he's coming back.

Mrs. Needy: It will be all right. You'll just have to be the big man of the house now. Come here and give me a hug big John. Now run on out and play. *(Wait for him to leave)* Poor kid. *(Cindy enters)* Hey Ms. pretty Cindy in pink why aren't you out playing with the others?

Cindy: I thought I would come and help you clean up.

Mrs. Needy: Oh, well thank you, but I'm afraid I'll have to clean this one up on my own. But I tell you what. If you really want to help me you can use that wet washcloth over there and wipe the tables down.

Cindy: O.k. Mrs. Needy.

My husband and I have a great relationship. As good as a ten-year marriage can get I'm sure. Yeah, we've had our ups and downs but we've managed to stay together no matter what. How did you know that? Well, the information is correct he did file for divorce a while ago, but we worked out our differences and I can say we are happy. Yes, I believe it was exactly that date. How is this helping anything? I'm sorry but I'm not seeing how this has anything to do with the investigation. He filed for divorce because we just weren't getting along. Yes, that's truth. Why would my husband say such a thing? *(Thinks for a minute)* He never told me that's why he left, I'm sorry, I just need a minute.
I'm barren. I had ovarian cancer a year or so before Tom and I got married. I think it brought us closer at the time. I spent a lot of time in-and-out of hospitals, too much time, but Tom was always there for me. That's when I knew that he was the one for me. However, after the cancer

we were told that we couldn't have a baby, something was permanently wrong with my ovaries. Of course we tried, God knows we tried, but we only came close once. I guess the miscarriage was a little ways before Tom filed for divorce but I never put the two together. I thought it was because I spent too much time at work and not enough time attending to his needs. See, after the miscarriage I almost lost it and the best way for me to forget was to concentrate on the children at work. When I first found out I was unable to have a child of my own I decided to start working for the Child Development Center so that I could be around such beauty; such life. Do you know what it's like to be so close to something you've always wanted only to have it ripped from you? You have no idea what I went through. The agony, the guilt, the blame. I lost myself in my work; I needed to be around the children. My little preschoolers became like my own children. I forgot that Tom was there our marriage was simply going through the motions, but then when he gave me divorce papers it made me realize what I must do. I had to save my marriage.
He never told me he left me because I couldn't give him a child. He told you this? That son-of-a-bitch. Oh, I'm sorry, I just wasn't expecting anything like this when I agree to come in for questioning. I just don't understand all of this.
Why are probing into my life? Why are you asking me questions as if I did it? Am I being suspected of something here? If you're suspecting me then I'm not saying another word until my lawyer comes.

Mrs. Needy: Are you having trouble sleeping Ms. Pretty Cindy in pink?

Cindy: Yes Mrs. Needy.

Mrs. Needy: Why can't you sleep dear, is there something wrong?

Cindy: My mommy and daddy were fighting last night. They said they hated each other. That's a no-no word Mrs. Needy.

Mrs. Needy: Sometimes adults fight when they're not getting along. I fight with my husband sometimes too, but I know that we'll be all right.

Cindy: Doesn't your daughter get sad when you fight?

Mrs. Needy: We don't have a daughter, actually that's part of the reason why we fight, we both blame each other for not having any perfect little ones like you, but you don't need to worry about those kinds of things. Everything is going to be all right I think I know exactly what I have to do.

Cindy: I would like to be your daughter Mrs. Needy. You would make a great mommy.

Mrs. Needy: Thank you sweetheart. Now close your eyes and go back to sleep. Shhh. I'm sure you'd make a great daughter.

I'm tired. I would like to go home now and rest. If you want me to answer more questions you'll just have to wait until I have rest and a lawyer, otherwise you're not getting another word from me. Fine, one more and I can go home? I was at home sick. Don't you think I blame myself enough for not being there when it happened? I still think if I had gone to work that day then I could have kept my eye out better. Mrs. Christy is a good assistant but she can't watch that big yard we call a playground by alone. On days when I'm not there I have Mrs. Christy take them outside a couple of extra times otherwise they get out of control and she can't handle them. Cindy used to love to play underneath the big juniper tree on the corner of the playground. Everyday she would play pretend house underneath that tree. Mrs. Christy must have just thought she was playing under the juniper but we never worried about Cindy, she never got into trouble. Had I been there I would have had her by my side. No one would have taken her. It's my fault I wasn't there it's my fault! I just can't do this anymore I need to go home.
Thank you. Yes I can come back tomorrow.

Cindy: Hello Mrs. Needy. How are you?

Mrs. Needy: I tired dear but I'm fine. Do you want to play a game?

Cindy: Yes I love games. Is it real fun?

Mrs. Needy: Oh yes it's real fun, it's pretend. See you and me are going to go far away on a trip and on this trip you and me are going to pretend to be daughter and mommy. You're the daughter and I'll be your mommy.

Cindy: But what about my real mommy and daddy?

Mrs. Needy: Oh I already told them and they said it would be o.k. How else do you think I would have known to find you playing underneath the tree? They told me to tell you to do what ever I said just like when you came to preschool, remember that day?

Cindy: Yes, but I'm scared. I miss my mommy and daddy.

Mrs. Needy: Don't be scared dear, your mommy's here.

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